

We made decisions and compromises. We decided, for example, to travel half the year and live in Buenos Aires the other half. We redivided the household chores. We decided to give up golf, a game Vicki found boring. I had played golf to relax away from the job. With no job to get away from, golf seemed a waste of time.

Little by little we worked through the changes. At the time, we weren't certain I was going to retire. If we couldn't settle some of the key issues, we could postpone our plans. That gave us a sense of control.

We finally concluded that retiring would be fun for both of us. I could fill my days with new interests. Freed from having to be a corporate wife, Vicki would have more time and energy for herself. We still had some doubts as to how we were going to spend our time. As I said in chapter 3, we never came up with a typical day, month, or year of retired life. Those specifics were too hard to imagine. But we had developed a to-do list to start things off. We had discussed the basics of our new life. And we were confident we could handle problems that would arise.

HELP FROM YOUR FRIENDS?

Besides your spouse, you should explain your retirement to your circle of extended family and friends. To the extent that "you attract what you are," friends mirror your views. That makes them especially good sounding boards.

Tell friends your ideas about retiring in simple, direct language. They won't put up with garbage like, "We've decided to metamorphose into a unique living situation that provides more opportunity for personal growth and interpersonal relationships." Talk like that and your friends will think one of your faucets is leaking. Instead, tell them in a clear, concise way what you're doing and why. Something like, "We're retiring. We can afford it and want to goof off. So why not?" A clean statement like that will elicit questions